SARTIQ

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Shootify Labs AG
trading as "Sartiq"

Sartiq Challenge: Neural Wave 2026

Problem Statement

Neural Wave Hackathon · 16–18 October 2026 · USI Lugano
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1. About Sartiq

Sartiq (Shootify Labs AG, Lugano) is a VC-funded startup providing AI-generated product images to the biggest European fashion companies.

Fashion brands produce garments and need to sell them online. To do so they need content: photos and videos of models wearing those garments in great-looking scenarios. Today that means booking a model, renting a studio and involving a whole team. It is slow and expensive. With Sartiq, they take a professional photo of the garment, upload it, and get the same (or better) photo.

We produce and publish more than 10'000 photos every month, which makes us one of the biggest photography studios in Europe, without owning a single camera.

The bottleneck will soon be the professional photo of the garment itself, because it needs logistics, people, skills and time. We call this step "the capture". We believe the same great garment photo can be obtained in a simple set with a smartphone and a lot of technology. Building an MVP of it is your challenge.

2. Problem statement

Can a smartphone plus a minimal set, driven by the right protocol and the right models, replace a studio shoot for a still-life packshot?

The two things that genuinely have to be captured honestly from the physical garment are its true light and colour. Get those wrong and no downstream model can recover them. So the question is: how lightweight can capture become?

Build a system that takes a lightweight smartphone capture of a real garment and produces a professional flat-lay packshot on a white background that holds up against the Sartiq reference image.

The twist: you design the capture protocol too. The way the garment is photographed can be part of your solution. A team that captures the garment cleverly and runs a simple pipeline can beat a team with a sophisticated model fed bad inputs.

3. What you decide

Your solution is the whole loop, and the interesting decisions are yours:

- **Capture**: how many shots, from which angles, laid flat or hung, and how you control light and colour with a phone (white-balance references, colour charts, multiple exposures, your own calibration).
- **Generation**: hosted image models with good prompts and conditioning, segmentation and relighting, detail crops, vision models that check the result, fine-tuning, or something we have not thought of. Custom training is optional: a strong solution can be built entirely from existing models.
- **The pipeline**: how the captured input becomes the final image, end to end.

There is no single intended answer. We fund the experiments (see section 7).

4. Data and materials

- **Example pairs** (about 380): amateur photos of garments, each with its professional flat-lay packshot. The pool mixes Sartiq studio pairs, real photos matched to brand packshots and generated photos. It is not labelled and contains some noise: exploring and cleaning it is part of the work. Use it for prompt design, model choice, measuring your pipeline, or training if you want to.
- **Dev set** (27 garments): phone photos only. The references stay with us and power a live leaderboard during the event.
- **On-site garments** (16): physical garments on a set at the venue. We supply phone photos of each, and you can shoot them yourself with your own protocol. These are the garments you are ranked on. Their references stay private, before and after the event.
- **On-site capture kit**: a lightweight set with a backdrop and one controllable light, so you can shoot and re-shoot as you refine your protocol. Bring your own smartphone.

> Repository (scorer, baselines, scripts, docs): github.com/shootify-io/neural-wave-2026
> Dataset: Google Drive folder (sartiq_neural_wave_2026.zip)

5. Deliverables

A working pipeline that, given a smartphone capture of a garment, outputs the still-life packshot. We do not care about the GUI: a phone app, a phone-to-desktop hand-off or a web form are all fine. We care about the procedure and the resulting image.

- One output image per on-site garment, in the folder layout described in the repository.
- The pipeline, runnable on the on-site garments.
- A short capture-protocol write-up: how a garment must be shot for your system to work, so the result is reproducible.

Deadline: **Sunday 18 October 2026, 11:00 CEST**. Hand-in details are announced at the event.

6. Evaluation

Generative quality has no single clean metric, so scoring is hybrid.

- **Automated score**: your outputs on the 16 on-site garments are compared with the Sartiq references by a frozen scorer, published in the repository so you can run it yourself. It measures closeness to the reference in:

40%	colour fidelity
25%	perceptual similarity (LPIPS)
15%	semantic similarity (CLIP)
15%	silhouette overlap
5%	structural similarity (SSIM)

  This ranks the teams and selects the finalists. It is a gate, not the final word: a good shot can differ from the reference and still be better.
- **Live leaderboard**: during the event we score the dev set at regular intervals and post team totals, so you know where you stand. It does not count towards the final ranking.

- **Sartiq jury**: finalists are scored by a Sartiq panel on commercial usability:
  - colour and material fidelity to the real garment,
  - silhouette and geometry correctness,
  - background and lighting cleanliness,
  - absence of artefacts (ghosting, warped seams, invented details).
- **Bonus**: robustness of the capture protocol, efficiency (time per garment) and degree of automation.

Outputs must come from your pipeline. Searching for and submitting existing product images of the garments is not allowed and disqualifies that garment.

7. Resources and contacts

- Each team gets a **fal.ai key with a $100 budget** (hosted image generation and editing) and an **OpenCode Go key with a $10 budget**, both for challenge work only, handed out at kickoff. We suggest OpenCode as the coding agent; it is not required.
- Sartiq: sartiq.com
- Felipe Cardoso (primary contact): felipe.cardoso@sartiq.com, +41 78 768 75 45
- Luca Pasini (secondary contact): luca.pasini@sartiq.com

8. Intellectual property

All code developed during the challenge remains the intellectual property of the participants. Sartiq (Shootify Labs AG) reserves the right to use, modify and incorporate this code for its own commercial purposes.

9. Why we run this: we're hiring

Let's be upfront: a primary goal of this challenge is to find talent. Sartiq is a small, VC-funded team, and the people we meet building hard things under pressure are exactly the people we want to hire.

What we offer: real flexibility in how and where you work, a competitive salary, and meaningful stock options. You own a piece of what you build.

Don't take our word for it. Find someone who already works at Sartiq on LinkedIn and ask them, directly and privately, what it's actually like.

If this is the kind of problem you'd happily pick up on a Monday morning, come find us at the event.